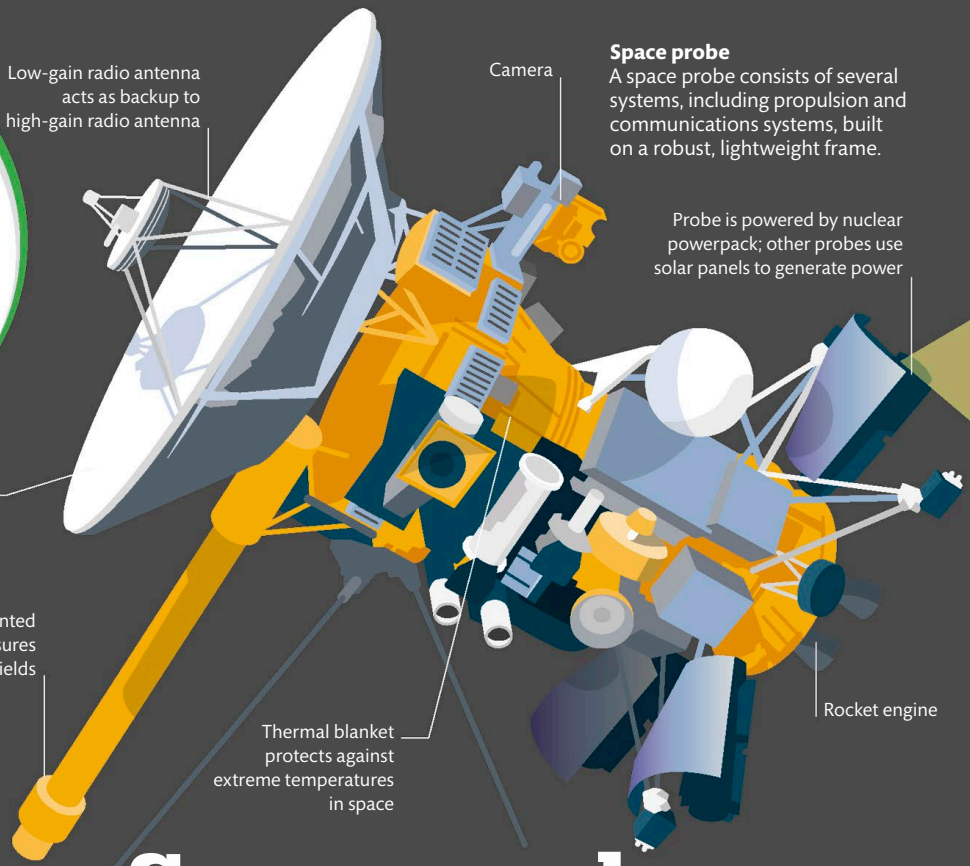
WHICH SPACE PROBE IS FARTHEST FROM EARTH?

Launched in 1977, Voyager 1 is the most distant human-made object, having traveled more than 13 billion miles (21 billion km) across space.



Space probes

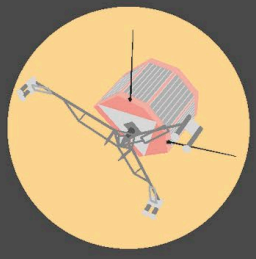
Space probes are unmanned spacecraft sent to explore the solar system. They have visited every planet and a few smaller bodies, such as comets and moons, taking images and sending back data.

Exploring space

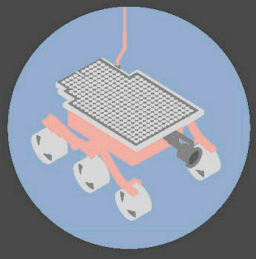
A space probe's primary role is to transport scientific instruments to remote parts of the solar system. On arriving at its target, a probe may go into orbit. Its cameras take photographs, and its instruments record a variety of measurements, including magnetic field strength, radiation and dust levels, and temperature. Data is returned to Earth by using radio waves (see pp.180–181).

Types of space probes

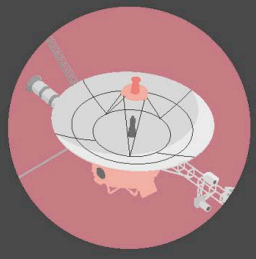
There are several types of space probes. Flybys pass planetary bodies and study them from a distance, while orbiters travel in circles around them. Some probes send mini-probes into an object's atmosphere; others send vehicles to land on the surface. Probes can also carry rovers, which are able to move across an object's surface.



Lander
A lander is designed to descend from a space probe and reach the surface of a planetary object. It remains stationary and sends information back to Earth.



Rover
Unlike landers, rovers are built to travel across the surface of a planetary object. They can be autonomous or semiautonomous.



Flyby
Flyby probes fly close to a planet or other body and collect data. They remain far enough away that they are not captured by the object's gravitational pull.